BUILT ON THE IIBA BABOK® GUIDE V3

BA Playbook

How to think, solve problems, work with people and manage requirements, built on the IIBA BABOK® Guide v3

Core concepts · Knowledge areas · Techniques · Testing · Competencies

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How this playbook is built

BABOK gives four layers. Use them from the top down: concepts first, then tasks, techniques and skills.

Core Concept Model

Six concepts that frame every piece of BA work: Change, Need, Solution, Stakeholder, Value, Context.

Why and what

→

Knowledge Areas

Six areas that group the 30 tasks a BA performs, from planning to evaluating a live solution.

What you do

→

Techniques

50 techniques, such as process modelling, root cause analysis and workshops, used inside the tasks.

How you do it

→

Underlying Competencies

The thinking, behaviour, knowledge and people skills that make a BA effective.

Who you are

Your People, Process and Technology lens sits on top of all four. See the last section.

01

Foundations

What business analysis is, the six core concepts, and how requirements are classified

What business analysis is

BABOK defines it in one sentence. Everything in this playbook serves it.

> *"Business analysis is the practice of enabling change in an enterprise by defining needs and recommending solutions that deliver value to stakeholders."*

Enabling change

You don't just document. You help the business move from how it works today to how it should work.

Defining needs

Find the real problem or opportunity behind a request, before anyone talks about solutions.

Recommending solutions

Compare options, including process-only changes and doing nothing, and say which gives most value.

Delivering value

Success is measured by what gets better for stakeholders, not by documents produced.

The Core Concept Model (BACCM)

Six concepts, each defined by the others. If one is unclear, the whole piece of work is at risk.

Change

The act of transformation in response to a need.

What is changing?

Need

A problem or opportunity to be addressed.

Why is this needed?

Solution

A specific way of satisfying one or more needs in a context.

How will we meet the need?

Stakeholder

A group or individual with a relationship to the change, need or solution.

Who is involved or affected?

Value

The worth, importance or usefulness of something to a stakeholder.

What is it worth, and to whom?

Context

The circumstances that influence and are influenced by the change.

What surrounds it: rules, culture, systems?

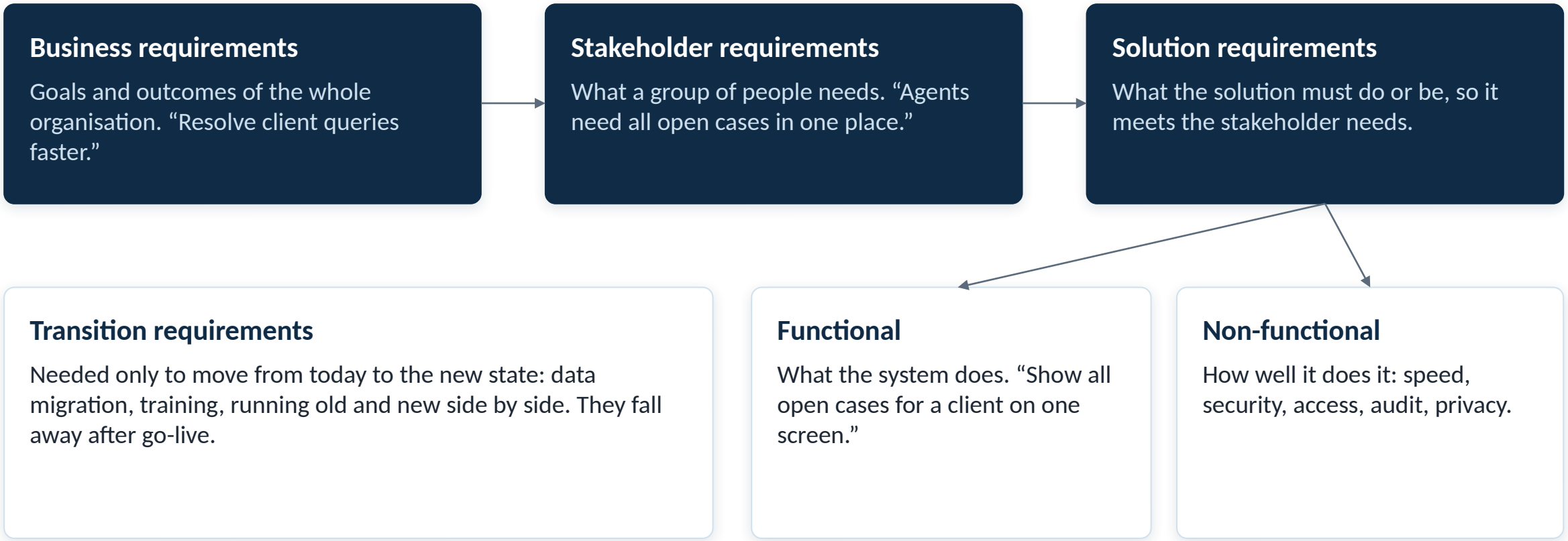
Use the core concepts every day

Before you start any request, workshop or document, answer these six questions in a line each.

Need	What problem or opportunity are we addressing? Write it in one sentence.
Stakeholder	Who does the work, who decides, who is affected, who must be consulted?
Value	What gets better, for whom, and how will we measure it?
Context	Which regulations, policies, systems and culture shape this?
Solution	What options do we have, including changing the process only?
Change	What has to change in people, process and technology to get there?

How BABOK classifies requirements

Knowing the type tells you who to ask, how to write it and how to test it.



A requirement describes a need. A design describes a way of meeting it. Keep the two apart until the need is agreed.

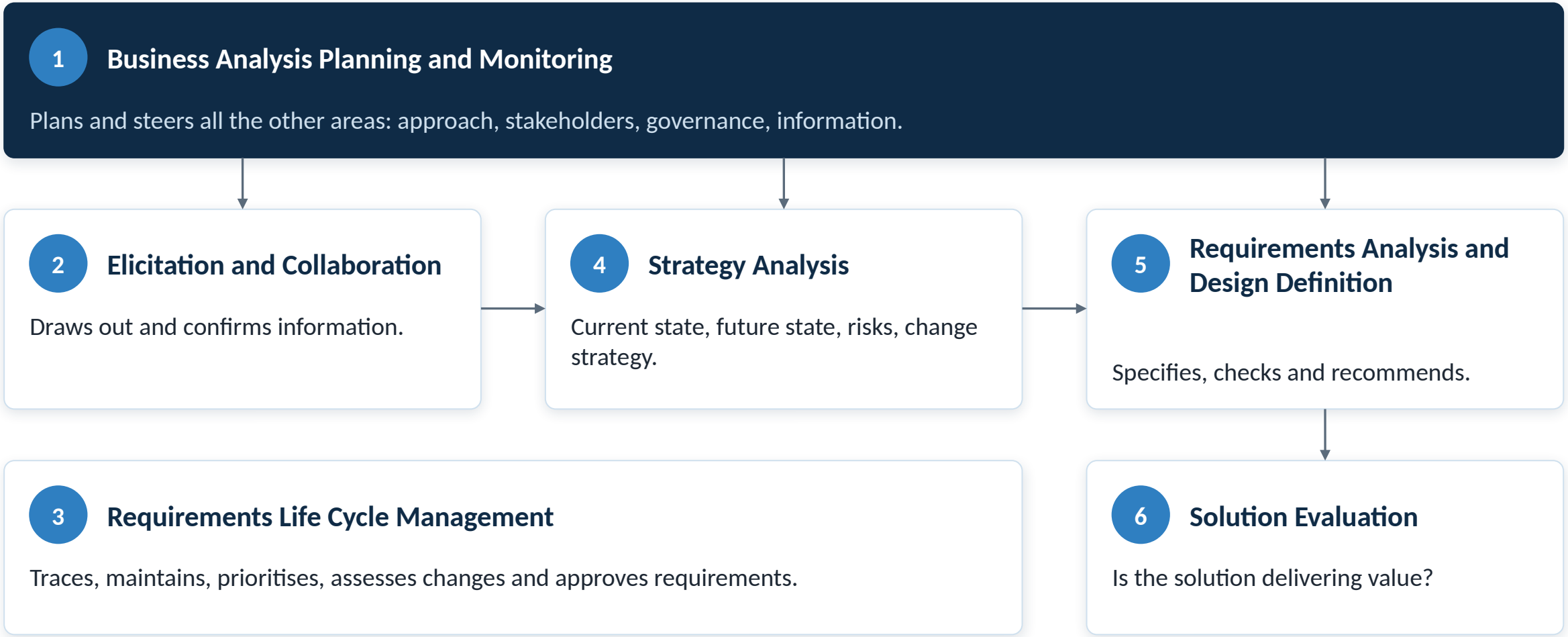
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The six knowledge areas

The 30 tasks BABOK describes, and what each one looks like in everyday work

How the knowledge areas fit together

Planning frames the work. Elicitation feeds the analysis. Requirements are managed through to a solution that gets evaluated.



1 · Planning and Monitoring

Organise the BA work: how you'll do it, who you'll involve, and how decisions and information are managed.

1 Plan the BA approach

Decide how you'll work (step by step or iterative), what you'll deliver, and when.

2 Plan stakeholder engagement

List stakeholders, map their power and interest, and agree how often to involve each.

3 Plan BA governance

Agree who approves requirements, how changes are decided and how priorities are set.

4 Plan information management

Decide where requirements live and how they're named, traced and stored.

5 Identify performance improvements

Review how your own BA work is going, and fix what slows you down.

Everyday output

A one-page BA plan: scope, stakeholders, approach, deliverables and the sign-off route.

2 · Elicitation and Collaboration

Draw information out of stakeholders, confirm you understood it, and keep people working together.

1 Prepare for elicitation

Set the goal, choose the technique, prepare questions and any draft maps.

2 Conduct elicitation

Interview, observe, run workshops, analyse documents and data.

3 Confirm elicitation results

Play it back and check it against other sources before relying on it.

4 Communicate BA information

Give the right people the right information in a form they'll use.

5 Manage stakeholder collaboration

Keep people engaged and committed, and deal with disagreement early.

Everyday output

Same-day notes: what you heard, decisions, actions with owners, open questions.

3 · Requirements Life Cycle Management

Keep requirements traceable, current and approved, from the first idea until the solution is retired.

1 Trace requirements

Link each one to its source, design, test case and solution.

2 Maintain requirements

Keep them accurate and reusable as the business changes.

3 Prioritise requirements

Rank by value, risk, cost, urgency and dependencies, for example with MoSCoW.

4 Assess requirements changes

Weigh each change's impact on value, scope, time, cost and risk.

5 Approve requirements

Get agreement from the right decision makers and record it.

Everyday output

A traceability matrix: ID, source, priority, story, test case, status, approver.

4 · Strategy Analysis

Understand why change is needed, define where the business should get to, and choose how to get there.

1 Analyse current state

Understand the need and how things work today: process, people, systems, data.

2 Define future state

Describe the target state and what success looks like.

3 Assess risks

Identify what could stop the change from delivering value, and plan for it.

4 Define change strategy

Compare options and pick the path, including any steps in between.

Everyday output

As-is and to-be process maps, a gap list, and a recommended option with its risks.

5 · Requirements Analysis and Design Definition

Turn what you've learned into clear requirements and designs, and recommend the solution with the most value.

1 Specify and model

Write and model requirements: process models, data models, user stories.

2 Verify requirements

Check quality: clear, consistent, complete, testable.

3 Validate requirements

Check they support the business need and goals.

4 Define requirements architecture

Organise them so they fit together without gaps or overlaps.

5 Define design options

Identify the different ways the need could be met.

6 Analyse value, recommend

Compare options on value, cost and risk, then recommend one.

6 · Solution Evaluation

Check whether a solution in use delivers the value it should, and recommend how to improve it.

1 Measure solution performance

Define and collect measures: turnaround, errors, SLAs, client outcomes.

2 Analyse performance measures

Compare the results with the value that was expected.

3 Assess solution limitations

Find what inside the solution stops it delivering value.

4 Assess enterprise limitations

Find what in the organisation holds it back: culture, structure, process.

5 Recommend actions

Propose changes to increase value, including retiring the solution.

Everyday output

A short review: target vs actual, causes of the gap, and recommended actions.

03

Doing the work

Solving problems, working with people, and writing requirements that hold up

Solving a problem, step by step

Eight steps for any request. Each one is rooted in a BABOK knowledge area.

1
Understand the need
Strategy Analysis

→

2
Plan the work
Planning and Monitoring

→

3
Engage stakeholders
Elicitation and Collaboration

→

4
Analyse the current state
Strategy Analysis

5
Find the root cause
Strategy Analysis

→

6
Design options, recommend
Requirements Analysis and Design

→

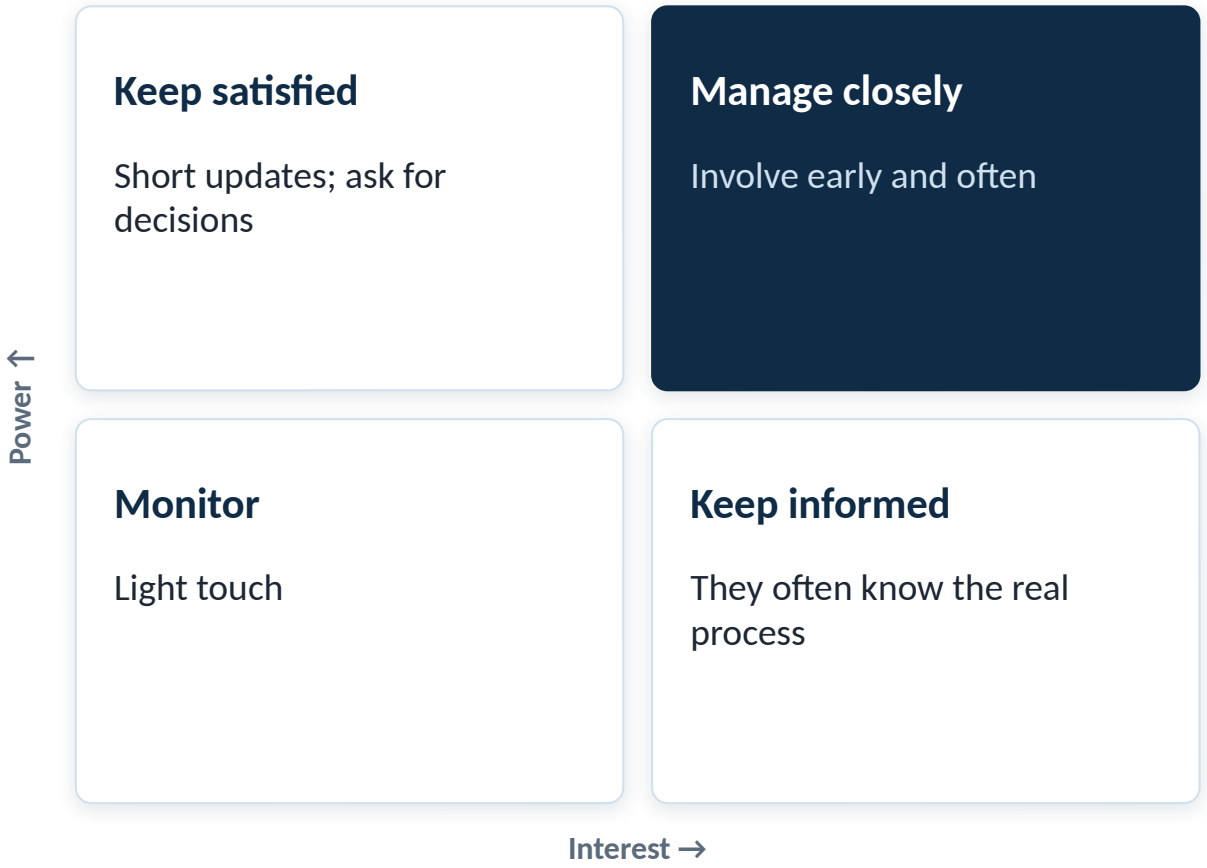
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Specify, check, approve
Requirements Analysis + Life Cycle Mgmt

→

8
Measure value after go-live
Solution Evaluation

Working with people

Planning and Monitoring tells you who to involve. Elicitation and Collaboration tells you how.



RACI: who does what

- **R** — **Responsible** does the work
- **A** — **Accountable** owns the result and signs off. Only one.
- **C** — **Consulted** gives input before
- **I** — **Informed** is told after

When people disagree: repeat each view back, separate facts from opinions, return to the agreed value, lay out options neutrally, and let the Accountable person decide. Write the decision down.

What makes a good requirement

BABOK's quality characteristics. Use them when you verify your own work before anyone else sees it.

Atomic

One need per statement, not split further

Complete

Enough detail to move forward

Consistent

Doesn't contradict other requirements

Concise

No extra words or content

Feasible

Achievable within budget, time and risk

Unambiguous

Only one way to read it

Testable

Someone can prove it was met

Prioritised

Ranked against the others

Understandable

In words its readers use

Writing requirements people can build and test

A user story states the need. Acceptance criteria make it testable.

User story

As a **[role]**, I want **[capability]**, so that **[benefit].**

Example: As an operations agent, I want to see every open case for a client on one screen, so that I don't miss a related case.

Check it with INVEST: Independent, Negotiable, Valuable, Estimable, Small, Testable.

Acceptance criteria

Given [situation], **when** [action], **then** [result].

Example: Given a client with two open cases, when the agent opens the profile, then both cases show with status and age.

Always cover the normal path, at least one exception, and any control, such as who may see or approve.

Verify versus validate

BABOK separates the two. Most rework comes from skipping one of them.

Verify



Is it built right?

- Checks the quality of the requirement itself
- Clear, consistent, complete, testable
- Done by you and peers, through reviews and checklists
- Happens before you share or sign off

Validate



Is it the right thing?

- Checks it supports the business need and goal
- Traces back to a real stakeholder need
- Done with stakeholders, against the value agreed
- Happens before and after the solution is built

Which BABOK technique to reach for

BABOK lists 50 techniques. These are the ones you'll use most in process and operations work.

You need to...	Reach for
Understand how work flows	Process Modelling, Observation, Interviews
Find why something goes wrong	Root Cause Analysis, Data Mining, Metrics and KPIs
Get a group to agree	Workshops, Brainstorming, Collaborative Games
Set boundaries	Scope Modelling, Business Model Canvas
Rank what matters	Prioritisation (e.g. MoSCoW), Backlog Management
Capture rules and controls	Business Rules Analysis, Roles and Permissions Matrix
Describe the data	Data Modelling, Data Dictionary, Data Flow Diagrams
Compare options	Decision Analysis, Cost-Benefit Analysis, Risk Analysis and Management
Make it testable	Acceptance and Evaluation Criteria, User Stories, Use Cases and Scenarios
Check quality	Reviews, Lessons Learned

BABOK's 50 techniques (1 of 2)

BABOK lists the techniques A to Z. Grouped here by what you use them for.

Elicit and collaborate

Draw information out of people

- Interviews
- Workshops
- Focus Groups
- Observation
- Survey or Questionnaire
- Brainstorming
- Collaborative Games
- Document Analysis
- Benchmarking and Market Analysis
- Prototyping
- Mind Mapping

Model processes and structure

Show how work and the business fit together

- Process Modelling
- Process Analysis
- Functional Decomposition
- Organisational Modelling
- Scope Modelling
- Business Capability Analysis
- Business Model Canvas
- Concept Modelling
- Sequence Diagrams
- State Modelling
- Use Cases and Scenarios

Model data and rules

Describe information and the rules on it

- Data Modelling
- Data Dictionary
- Data Flow Diagrams
- Data Mining
- Glossary
- Business Rules Analysis
- Decision Modelling
- Interface Analysis
- Roles and Permissions Matrix

BABOK's 50 techniques (2 of 2)

11 + 11 + 9 + 7 + 8 + 4 = 50. The grouping is a working aid, not part of BABOK itself.

Specify and manage requirements

Write, rank, track and check them

- User Stories
- Acceptance and Evaluation Criteria
- Non-Functional Requirements Analysis
- Prioritisation
- Backlog Management
- Item Tracking
- Reviews

Analyse and decide

Find causes, compare options, justify change

- Root Cause Analysis
- SWOT Analysis
- Decision Analysis
- Risk Analysis and Management
- Business Cases
- Financial Analysis
- Estimation
- Vendor Assessment

Measure and engage

Track performance and stakeholders

- Metrics and Key Performance Indicators (KPIs)
- Balanced Scorecard
- Lessons Learned
- Stakeholder List, Map or Personas

Five techniques you'll use most, explained

How each one works in practice, in process and operations work.

Process Modelling

Draw the flow in BPMN: start and end events, tasks, decisions, swimlanes per role. Map as-is first, check it with the doers, then design the to-be.

Root Cause Analysis

Ask “why?” five times, or use a fishbone with People, Process, Technology, Data and Environment. Confirm the cause with evidence before you fix it.

Workshops

Clear goal, the right people, an agenda and a draft to react to. Make decisions visible on screen, and send actions within 24 hours.

Business Rules Analysis

Pull out the rules hidden in a process: who may approve, which limits apply, which checks are mandatory. Write each rule once, in plain words.

Acceptance and Evaluation Criteria

Agree up front how you'll know a requirement is met. These become the basis of your UAT test cases.

04

Testing requirements

QA, test levels, UAT, test cases and defects: proving the solution meets the requirements

Where testing sits in BABOK

BABOK covers the BA's part of testing. The detailed test practice comes from testing standards such as ISTQB.

Verify requirements

Before anything is built, check each requirement is clear, consistent and testable. An untestable requirement can't pass UAT.

Acceptance and Evaluation Criteria

The technique that turns each requirement into conditions you can test. These criteria drive the test cases.

Trace requirements

Link every requirement to its test cases, so nothing goes untested and every defect traces to a need.

Solution Evaluation

After go-live, check the solution delivers the value expected. Testing proves it works; evaluation proves it helps.

Quality assurance versus testing

QA prevents defects in how the work is done. Testing finds defects in what was built.

Quality assurance (QA)



Are we working in a way that prevents defects?

- Focus on the process
- Standards, templates, checklists
- Peer reviews of requirements and designs
- Entry and exit criteria for each stage
- Lessons learned feed back into the method

Testing (quality control)

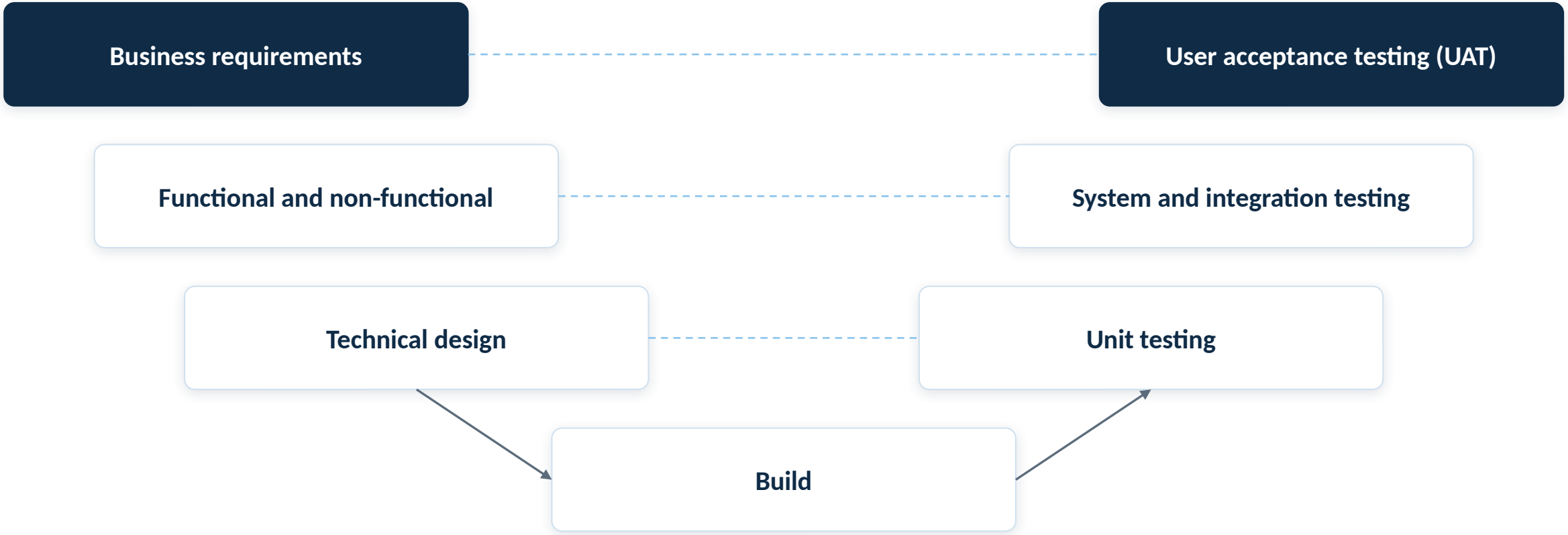


Does what we built work as required?

- Focus on the product
- Test cases run against requirements
- Defects logged, fixed and retested
- Done at several levels, from unit to UAT
- Ends with evidence and sign-off

Test levels: the V-model

Each requirement level on the left is proven by a test level on the right.



Who tests: developers run unit tests, the test or IT team runs system and integration testing, and the business runs UAT, with the BA preparing and coordinating it. Regression testing repeats earlier tests after every fix.

Types of testing to know

Levels say when you test. Types say what you're testing for.

Functional

Does each feature do what the requirement says?

Negative

Does it handle wrong or missing input safely, with a clear message?

Regression

Did a fix or change break something that worked before?

Smoke

A quick check that the main functions work before deeper testing starts.

Non-functional

Speed, security and access, audit trail, usability, availability.

End to end

The whole process across systems and teams, as a client would experience it.

Running UAT, step by step

The BA plans and coordinates UAT. The business tests and signs off.

1 Plan

Scope, testers, environment, dates, entry and exit criteria

2 Prepare

Scenarios, test cases, test data, user access

3 Brief

Walk testers through the change and how to log results

4 Execute

Run test cases, record actual results and evidence

5 Log defects

Same day, with steps, evidence and severity

6 Retest

Confirm fixes and run regression

7 Report

Passed, failed, open defects and risks

8 Sign off

Business owner accepts against exit criteria

Entry criteria: system testing passed, environment and data ready, testers briefed. **Exit criteria:** all test cases run, no open critical or high defects.

Scenario, test case, test script

Three levels of detail. Write them in this order.

Test scenario

What situation are we testing?

Example: A consumer disputes an account that is shown as overdue.

Test case

What conditions, data and expected result?

Example: A dispute open longer than the allowed time is flagged as overdue and escalated.

Test script

Exactly which steps, screen by screen?

Example: 1. Log in as an agent 2. Open the dispute queue 3. Filter by age 4. Open the dispute 5. Check the overdue flag and escalation.

Anatomy of a good test case

If someone else can run it and get the same result without asking you, it's written well.

Field	What to write	Example
ID and title	Unique ID and a short name	*TC-014 · Overdue dispute is escalated*
Requirement	The requirement or story it proves	*REQ-07 · Disputes past the deadline are escalated*
Preconditions	What must be true before you start	*A dispute exists that is past its deadline*
Test data	The exact records or values used	*Test consumer A, dispute D-1003*
Steps	Numbered actions	*1. Open queue 2. Filter by age 3. Open D-1003*
Expected result	What should happen, stated so it can be checked	*Marked overdue; escalated to team leader*
Actual result and status	What happened: pass, fail or blocked	*Filled in during execution*
Evidence	Screenshot or record reference	*Attached when run*

Designing test cases that catch defects

Test where defects hide: at the edges, in the exceptions and in the rule combinations.

Positive and negative

Test the normal path, then wrong, missing and unexpected input.

Boundary values

Test on, just inside and just outside a limit. For a 20-day rule: day 19, day 20, day 21.

Equivalence partitioning

Group inputs that behave the same, and test one from each group instead of all of them.

Decision tables

List every combination of conditions in a rule and the expected outcome for each.

State transition

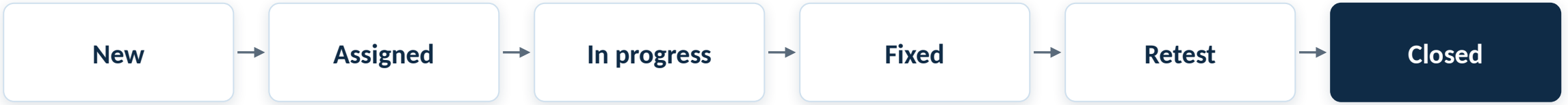
Test every allowed move between statuses, such as open to resolved, and that blocked moves fail.

Role and access

Check each role can do what it should and can't do what it shouldn't.

Defects: lifecycle, severity and priority

Severity is how bad the impact is. Priority is how soon it must be fixed. They're not always the same.



Failed retest → Reopened, back to Assigned

Severity	Meaning	Example
Critical	Can't go live: core function fails, wrong data or a broken control	Case closes without the required approval
High	Major function affected, poor or no workaround	Search returns the wrong client
Medium	Works, but not as specified; workaround exists	Report column in the wrong order
Low	Cosmetic	Spelling mistake on a label

A good defect log has steps to reproduce, test data, expected vs actual result, evidence, severity, environment and status.

Traceability ties it all together

One line per requirement. It answers: where did this come from, was it built, was it tested, was it signed off?

Req ID	Requirement	Source	Priority	Test cases	Defects	Status
REQ-07	Overdue disputes are escalated	Workshop, 3 Mar	Must	TC-014, TC-015	DF-22 (closed)	Passed
REQ-08	Agent sees all open cases for a client	Ops interview	Must	TC-016	None	Passed
REQ-09	Consumer notified when resolved	Policy	Should	TC-017, TC-018	DF-25 (open)	Failed
REQ-10	Monthly ageing report	Team leader	Could	TC-019	None	Not run

Illustrative example. No sign-off while a Must requirement is failed or untested.

05

You as a BA

The competencies BABOK expects, where your work sits, and your People, Process, Technology lens

Underlying competencies

BABOK's six groups of skills. Pick one each quarter to work on deliberately.

Analytical thinking

Problem solving, systems thinking, decision making, conceptual and visual thinking, learning.

Behavioural characteristics

Ethics, personal accountability, trustworthiness, organisation and time management, adaptability.

Business knowledge

Business acumen, industry, organisation, solution and methodology knowledge.

Communication skills

Verbal, non-verbal and written communication, and active listening.

Interaction skills

Facilitation, leadership and influencing, teamwork, negotiation and conflict resolution, teaching.

Tools and technology

Office and productivity tools, BA tools such as modelling software, and communication tools.

BABOK perspectives: where your work sits

Perspectives show how BA work changes by context. Process work sits mainly in Business Process Management.

Business Process Management

Design, model, measure and improve end-to-end processes and their controls. Your core today.

Agile

Short cycles, a prioritised backlog, user stories and constant feedback.

Information Technology

Requirements for building or changing systems, from specification to UAT.

Business Intelligence

Turning data into information for decisions: reports, dashboards, data models.

Business Architecture

The big picture: capabilities, value streams and how the organisation fits together.

Value streams come from Business Architecture, and your Power BI work from Business Intelligence. You already work across perspectives.

Your People, Process, Technology lens, through BABOK

PPT is how you look at a problem. BABOK gives each side its concepts, tasks and skills.

People

Core concepts
Stakeholder, Value

Knowledge areas
Planning and Monitoring (stakeholder engagement); Elicitation and Collaboration

Competencies
Interaction and communication skills

Ask
Who does the work, who decides, who benefits?

Process

Core concepts
Need, Change, Context

Knowledge areas
Strategy Analysis; Requirements Analysis and Design (process models)

Competencies
Analytical thinking, business knowledge

Ask
How does the work flow, and where does it break?

Technology

Core concepts
Solution

Knowledge areas
Requirements Analysis and Design (design options); Solution Evaluation

Competencies
Tools and technology

Ask
Which system supports each step, and what could be automated?

Before any piece of work, ask

Need

Why is this needed?

Stakeholder

Who is involved or affected?

Value

What gets better, for whom?

Context

What rules, systems and culture apply?

Solution

What are the options?

Change

What must change in people, process and technology?

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